

Suànróng Xiǎobáicài 蒜蓉小白菜

Baby Bok Choy with Ginger and Garlic

Serves: 4 — Total Time: 45 minutes — Difficulty: ●○○○

- 4 teaspoons vegetable oil, divided
- 1 tablespoon grated fresh ginger
- 1 garlic clove, minced
- 2 tablespoons oyster sauce
- 2 teaspoons toasted sesame oil
- ½ teaspoon cornstarch
- 8 small heads baby bok choy
(1½ to 2 ounces each), halved
lengthwise, washed thoroughly,
and spun dry
- 2 tablespoons water

Test Kitchen Tip

Recipe developer José Maldonado

notes: "As bok choy grows, grit collects between the base of the leaves. Gently peel back the leaves as you rinse them. Let the water do all the work. The leaves are fragile, and too much pressure can snap a leaf clean from its base, affecting your presentation."

Gastronomically speaking, China is more continent than country. One vegetable you'll find across many regions of Chinese cooking is bok choy. These hearty members of the cabbage family grow quickly and in most climates, contributing to their ubiquity.

The key to cooking bok choy has always been striking a textural balance: How do you time it so the firm stalks soften to a tender crispness before the green leaves get too limp? Cooking with baby bok choy—as opposed to its larger counterpart—solves some of the dilemma. We also cut the baby bok choy in half lengthwise, which has the added benefit of providing more direct access to where most of the dirt and grit hide, making the vegetable easier to clean. — Jeffrey

If using heads larger than 2 ounces each, quarter them instead of halving. We spin the bok choy dry after washing to avoid adding too much water to the wok.

- 1 Combine 1 teaspoon vegetable oil, ginger, and garlic in small bowl; set aside. Whisk oyster sauce, sesame oil, and cornstarch together in second small bowl; set aside.
- 2 Heat empty 14-inch flat-bottomed wok over high heat until just beginning to smoke. Reduce heat to medium, drizzle remaining 1 tablespoon vegetable oil around perimeter of wok, and heat until just smoking. Add bok choy and water (water will sputter), cover, and cook, shaking wok occasionally, for 2 minutes.
- 3 Uncover, toss bok choy, then push to 1 side of wok. Add ginger-garlic mixture to clearing and cook, mashing mixture into wok, until fragrant, about 20 seconds. Stir ginger-garlic mixture into bok choy and continue to cook, tossing slowly but constantly, until all water has evaporated, stems are crisp-tender, and leaves are wilted, 1 to 2 minutes. Add oyster sauce mixture and cook, stirring constantly, until sauce is thickened and coats bok choy, about 15 seconds. Serve.

